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RAIL WEB SPREADS

Bullock Carts, the Shaitan and Rail Elephants

India’s first passenger train running on the 21-mile Bombay–Thana line was a runaway success in the very first month. It was started on 16 April 1853, and regular runs began from 18 April. By 30 April, trains on this small stretch had already ferried 21,922 passengers, earning ₹9,109, 3 annas and 8 paise. By May, the number of passengers had risen to 40,071½ [49] and by December to 61,413½.

WHEN BULLOCK CARTS RACED STEAM TRAINS

Traditional modes of transit began to feel the heat as trains became more and more popular. Bullock carts, for example, fell out of favour, as trains became the preferred mode of cargo transport. Bullock cart owners were furious. They decided to put up a fight and began charging one rate from the hinterland to Bombay so as to prevent business from going over to the railways. This succeeded for a while, worrying railway traffic managers. The worried agent (the manager) of the GIPR in 1868 wrote a harried letter to the Railway Board, suggesting that the railways appoint a person to solicit traffic. Excerpts from his letter are below:

> We are, I regret to say, threatened with a severe competition on the part of the bullock cart drivers from cotton markets in the south-eastern district. The whole of the cotton markets on the south-eastern district are situated at a distance varying from 20 to 120 miles from our station, and the bullock men have combined to charge the same rate to our stations as